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Obedience of Hegemony: the Ideology behind the Great Mongol Empire

“Conquering the world on horseback is easy; it is dismounting and governing that is hard.”¹ Born as skillful cavalymen and superior archers, the Mongols conquered more than 30,000,000 km² of land and captured more than a hundred million of people in less than eight decades². However, it was not until the Mongol Empire became a superpower that the real difficulties of governance emerged, since the empire was extremely large without parallel ever in human history, and in her vast and diverse land, there lived Chinese, Christians, Muslims, and other people with highly different cultural backgrounds, political traditions, and religious beliefs. How to unify these people under the dominance of the sole empire? My answer is that Mongols ruled their empire and vassals with the ideology of obedience, which consists of the recognition of Mongol sovereignty, regular tribute and trade with Mongols, a certain degree of autonomy in some area, and merciless penalty for any sign of unfaithfulness. To fully understand the meaning of obedience, let us look back to the history itself first.

In 1245, a missionary was dispatched from Christendom to the East. His name was John of Plano Carpini, and his mission was to reconnoiter the Mongols (or Tartars)³. The journey of John of Plano Carpini brought a panoramic yet biased picture (for example, he always describes the Mongols as “tyranny” and “not trustworthy”⁴ in his book) of the Mongol Empire. After years of hesitation, for the first time, the Christendom world finally gained

¹ Said to Genghis Khan, according to:

Thomas Meagher and Buck Brannaman, *The Gigantic Book of Horse Wisdom*, 2007 edition, 408.

² “Mongol Empire” , *Wikipedia, the Free Encyclopedia*. Last modified September 17, 2019.

<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Mongol_Empire#Early_organization>

³ “Missionary from Rome: Bridging East and West” , *Asia for Educators, Columbia University*. Web. Sept 2019.

<<http://afe.easia.columbia.edu/mongols/history/history3.htm>>

⁴ John of Plano Carpini, “History of the Mongols (c. 1248)” 38, 44. Accessed in class, September 2019.

some insight into their formidable yet mysterious rival, who cultivated the warriors that were not only “most arrogant to other people and look down on all”, but also “more obedient to their masters than any other man in the world”⁵. Despite John of Plano Carpini’s prejudiced description, his travel notes objectively reflect some key features of the Mongol regime that powerfully prove its emphasis on the absolute obedience of the empire’s hegemony.

First, the obedience is mirrored by the Mongol way to treat peace. According to John of Plano Carpini, Mongols “never make peace except with those who submit to them” and they firmly stuck to Genghis Khan’s creed that “bring all nations into subjection if possible”⁶. By forcing other nations to admit the unquestionable supremacy of the empire, Mongols accomplished their first step to establish the fundamental basis of ruling. In company with their “generous” attitude towards the subdued nations, Mongols in the meantime also conducted ruthless massacres to those who dared to resist. By means of revengeful killings, Mongols warned the whole world that the severe punishment and miserable fate of disloyalty, frightening all potential rioters and rebels.

But repression only by force was far from enough to sustain dominance, let alone the Mongol population was not in the majority of the empire’s entire population. Therefore, to compensate the inferiority of underpopulation, Mongols established close cooperation with local aristocrats in their territory. As John of Plano Carpini recorded in his reports, Mongols “send for the rulers of countries, bidding them come to them without delay”⁷. Besides, Mongols also granted a certain degree of autonomy to those local aristocrats in some specific area, such as Tibet and Korea, in exchange for their loyalty of the empire. However, if the

⁵ John of Plano Carpini, “The Mongol Mission” , in Dawson, Christopher (ed). *New York: AMS Press*, 1980.

⁶ John of Plano Carpini, “History of the Mongols (c. 1248)” , 38.

⁷ John of Plano Carpini, “History of the Mongols (c. 1248)” , 39.

local rulers who had admitted Mongol governance that ever had a dispute, “then they have to go to the Emperor of the Tartars to plead their case”⁸. By preserving the power of making final decision, Mongols realized a special form of centralization of power under a rather decentralized political system.

Furthermore, regular tribute and trade was also a vital link between Mongols and non-Mongol ethnic groups both politically and economically. “The Tartars take tribute from and deal leniently with nations a long distance away... they do these so that these neighboring countries will not bring an army against them or be afraid to surrender to them”⁹, by tribute and trade, both Mongols and other nations benefited from goods exchange and peaceful international environment, leading to the prosperity of important entrepots and market places.

In conclusion, the ideology of obedience under Mongol regime had a profound influence with both positive and negative aspects, the later empires such as the Spanish Empire, Qing Dynasty of China¹⁰, and the Great Britain all more or less borrowed from the Mongols as well as learned from their mistakes, and some of the Mongol Empire’s conventions even cast impact on today’s world. For example, during the colonization period when big capitalist powers were greedily and consistently seeking the global hegemony, achieving obedience by establishing domination with the upper echelons of colonial countries became a common practice around the world. Although there may be differences in term of specific means of ruling, but the ideology behind the Mongol Empire and modern superpowers’ governance remains basically unchanged, that is, seeking and maintaining absolute obedience over their people and neighbors.

⁸ John of Plano Carpini, “History of the Mongols (c. 1248)” , 40.

⁹ John of Plano Carpini, “History of the Mongols (c. 1248)” , 41.

¹⁰ Qing Dynasty was the last imperial dynasty and the second dynasty (the first was Yuan) that was not founded by Han Chinese.